

Email Phishing Investigation Report

Findings

1. **Date/Time:** 26 Jan 2021 01:41:18 EST (06:41:18 UTC)
2. **Recipient:** themajoronearth@gmail.com
3. **Subject:** A Hope to CoCanDa
4. **Spoofed Sender:** Bill <billjobs@microapple.com>
5. **Return Path:** billjobs@microapple.com
6. **Reply-To:** negeja3921@pashter.com
7. **Source IP:** 93.99.104.210
8. **SPF:** Failed
9. **Artifacts:** Base64 encoded email body; PDF attachment containing additional Base64 data; extracted JPEG, PDF and Excel files
10. **Decoded Clues:** JPEG directed analyst to Money.xlsx; Excel contained Base64 revealing attacker location: 'The Martian Colony, Beside Interplanetary Spaceport.'

Investigation Summary

The investigation identified a phishing email using spoofed branding and Base64-encoded content to conceal its message. The sender address impersonated a legitimate organization while the Reply-To address pointed to a different domain. SPF validation failed, indicating the sending host was not authorized. CyberChef decoding revealed the email message and an attached PDF containing another Base64 payload. Further decoding extracted a JPEG, PDF and Excel workbook. The JPEG instructed the analyst to inspect the Excel workbook, which contained Base64-encoded data identifying the fictional attacker location as 'The Martian Colony, Beside Interplanetary Spaceport'.

Who, What, When, Where, Why, How

Who

Victim: themajoronearth@gmail.com. Threat actor spoofed 'Bill <billjobs@microapple.com>' while directing replies to negeja3921@pashter.com.

What

A phishing email delivered Base64-encoded content with layered attachments intended to hide information and encourage further interaction.

When

Email received on 26 Jan 2021 01:41:18 EST (06:41:18 UTC). No evidence provided that activity continued after delivery.

Where

Delivered to the recipient mailbox from source IP 93.99.104.210 via emkei.cz infrastructure. Final decoded clue referenced 'The Martian Colony, Beside Interplanetary Spaceport' (challenge artifact).

Why

Likely intended to test or demonstrate phishing analysis techniques through obfuscation and social engineering.

How

The attacker used sender spoofing, SPF failure, Base64 encoding, nested attachments and hidden data requiring CyberChef decoding.

Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

- Source IP: 93.99.104.210
- Sender: billjobs@microapple.com
- Reply-To: negeja3921@pashter.com
- SPF Failure
- Subject: A Hope to CoCanDa

Recommendations

1. Quarantine the email and block the sender, reply-to address and source IP if appropriate.
2. Review additional mailboxes for similar messages using the sender, subject, IP and reply-to indicators.
3. Verify SPF, DKIM and DMARC enforcement to reduce spoofing risk.
4. Educate users not to open unexpected attachments or respond to suspicious messages.
5. Submit the attachments to a sandbox for dynamic analysis before allowing access.
6. Document all extracted artifacts and retain them as evidence.